

Plain Language Statement

The University of Melbourne/ Melbourne Veterinary School



Project: Assessing cat ownership-related exposure to *Toxoplasma gondii*: developing a survey protocol for Victorian cat owners

Primary researcher: Master student of Science (Epidemiology)

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Introduction

Thank you for your interest in participating in this research project. The following few pages will provide you with further information about the project, so that you can decide if you would like to take part in this research.

Please take the time to read this information carefully. You may ask questions about anything you don't understand or want to know more about.

Your participation is voluntary. If you don't wish to take part, you don't have to. If you begin participating, you can also stop at any time.

What is this research about?

This research is about everyday cat ownership practices that may affect exposure to *Toxoplasma gondii*, a parasite that can spread between cats and people. The aim is to understand how common these practices are among cat owners in Victoria and whether they differ across groups of people.

What will I be asked to do?

You will be asked to complete an online questionnaire about cat ownership and everyday household practices, such as litter cleaning, disposal of cat faeces, outdoor access of cats, and hygiene-related behaviours. It should take about 10–15 minutes to complete. You will not be asked any medical questions or to provide any personal medical information.

What are the possible benefits?

This research may help improve understanding of cat ownership practices that could affect exposure to *Toxoplasma gondii*. In the future, this may help inform public health education and guidance for people who live with cats.

What are the possible risks?

This study involves minimal risk. Some people may feel slightly uncomfortable answering questions about their household habits or hygiene practices. You do not have to answer any question you do not want to answer, and you may stop the survey at any time before submitting it.

Do I have to take part?

No. Participation is completely voluntary. You are able to withdraw at any time. No. Taking part is completely voluntary. You do not have to take part if you do not want to.

If you decide to take part, you may stop the survey at any time before submitting your responses. Because the survey is anonymous, once you have submitted your questionnaire it will not be possible to withdraw your data.

Will I hear about the results of this project?

A summary of the study findings may be made available on request after the project is completed. The results may also be included in a student research report and may be presented in academic publications or presentations. No individual participant will be identified in any report or publication.

What will happen to information about me?

Your survey responses will be collected anonymously. You will not be asked to provide your name or contact details, and no information that directly identifies you will be included in the research data.

The information you provide will be stored securely by the University of Melbourne and will only be accessed by the research team for the purposes of this project. The results of the study may be included in a student research report and may be presented in academic publications or presentations, but no individual participant will be identified.

Because the survey is anonymous, it will not be possible to withdraw your data after you have submitted your responses. Research data will be retained and managed in accordance with University of Melbourne requirements. No audio, video, or photographic materials will be collected in this study.

Where can I get further information?

If you would like more information about the project, please contact:

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or

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Who can I contact if I have any concerns about the project?

This project has received human research ethics approval/exemption [*delete as applicable*] from The University of Melbourne, project ID number: [*insert Infonetica project ID here*]. If you have any concerns or complaints about the conduct of this research project, which you do not wish to discuss with the research team, you should contact the Research Integrity Administrator, Office of Research Ethics and Integrity, University of Melbourne, VIC 3010. Tel: +61 3 8344 1376 or Email: research-integrity@unimelb.edu.au. All complaints will be treated confidentially. In any correspondence, please provide the name of the research team and/or the name or project ID number of the research project.